

Exercise Scoring Rulebook (Pilates Movements)

Below are detailed form-and-error criteria for each exercise. For each body part (in order of priority), we describe the correct alignment and the common faults that lead to form deductions. References to biomechanics and Pilates instruction guides support each criterion.

Plank (Forearm Plank)

- **Lower Back (Priority 1):** The spine should be neutral and in a straight line from head to heels. Avoid **arching or sagging** the lumbar spine; this transfers load away from the core and can strain the low back ¹ ². Excessive lumbar extension (arching up) or dropping the hips toward the floor signals weak core engagement and should be penalized.
- **Core (Priority 2):** Abdominals and glutes must be actively engaged to support the spine. If the hips drop or rise (pelvic tilt) as fatigue sets in, it indicates the core is not holding tension ². Maintain “scooped” abs and lifted pelvis to keep the torso rigid ¹.
- **Shoulders (Priority 3):** Elbows should be directly under shoulders, and shoulders **should not shrug or creep toward the ears** ³. A common fault is elevating the traps (shoulder shrug) or letting the shoulders collapse forward, which loads the neck/shoulder improperly. The scapulae should be stable (shoulders depressed and retracted) so that the arms drive into the floor to support the torso ³.
- **Neck (Priority 4):** The head must stay in line with the spine. Do **not crane the head up or let it drop** ⁴. The neck should remain neutral (imagine holding a tennis ball between chin and chest). Looking too far forward (neck hyperextension) or letting the head fall toward the mat will lead to strain ⁴.
- **Hips (Priority 5):** The entire body should form one straight plank. Allowing **hip sagging or piking** (raising the butt too high) are both errors ². Hip sagging is a sign of poor core control, while overly high hips shift the load to the shoulders and impair full-body tension. Both deviations should incur penalty points.

Side Plank (Lateral Plank)

- **Hips (Priority 1):** Keep the hips **square and lifted** in line with the rest of the body ⁵ ⁶. The most common error is **dropping the bottom hip** toward the floor. A hip drop means the obliques and glute of the supporting side are not braced. Actively lift the bottom hip upward to maintain a straight side profile ⁵. Also watch for **pelvic rotation** (hips twisting) – both hips should stay stacked. Hip-level errors receive the highest deduction.
- **Shoulder/Arm (Priority 2):** The supporting elbow (or hand, if on hand) should be directly under the shoulder. Avoid **elbow too far out** or **shoulder collapse** ⁷. Placing the elbow under the shoulder and pressing the shoulder blade down engages the obliques instead of the arm. If the shoulder rounds forward or shrugs upward, points should be deducted.
- **Core (Priority 3):** Engage the oblique and transverse abdominals to stabilize. A failure to brace the core often shows as **trunk sagging or torso rotation**. Watch the torso remain straight — twisting or

bending of the spine in the plank indicates low core engagement. Penalties apply for any noticeable lateral bend or “scooping” of the torso as if collapsing toward the ground.

- **Neck (Priority 4):** Keep the head in neutral alignment. The neck should continue the spine's line ⁸. Avoid **letting the head drop** or **looking up** at the ceiling ⁸. Tucking the chin slightly protects the cervical spine. If the athlete cranes the neck or tucks too aggressively, deduct points.

References: Proper side-plank technique emphasizes hip elevation and spinal alignment ⁹ ⁶. Keeping the bottom hip lifted targets the obliques correctly, and maintaining a long, straight line avoids low-back arching and neck strain ⁸ ⁶.

The Hundred Hold (Pilates Hundred)

- **Core (Priority 1):** The abdominal wall must remain fully contracted. The goal is to “scoop” the abs so the lower spine stays flat on the mat. If the back starts to arch (spine “peels” off the floor) or the legs rise too high to maintain position, it means the core has disengaged ¹⁰. Deduct points if the lower back arches or if the shoulders pop off the mat, as both show core failure.
- **Lower Back (Priority 2):** The lumbar spine should be gently **pressed into the mat** (imprinted). If the legs lower too far, the low back will arch – this is a sign the core isn't supporting the movement ¹⁰. Avoid any visible gap under the back. Any excessive extension (arching) of the back should lose points.
- **Neck/Head (Priority 3):** The head is lifted but the chin should **tuck slightly** toward the chest ¹¹. A common fault is **jutting the chin upward**, which strains the neck ¹¹. The head-neck axis should remain an extension of the spine. Penalize if the chin pokes up (compressing the cervical spine) or the head flops back.
- **Hips/Legs (Priority 4):** Leg angle should be no lower than where the back starts to lift. As a rule, keep legs around 45° or higher unless flexibility and core control allow more ¹⁰. Legs that drop too low causing the back to arch are errors. If legs are uneven or one hip twists up, deduct points for hip misalignment.
- **Shoulders/Arms (Priority 5):** Shoulders must stay relaxed and **drawn down** away from the ears ¹². The arms pump small 6–8” motions – if the shoulders shrug up or hunch toward the neck, deduct points ¹². The emphasis is on shoulder blades sliding down the back.

References: Instructional cues for the Hundred emphasize a flat lumbar spine and a tucked chin ¹¹ ¹⁰. Legs should only lower as far as the abs can control without back arch, and shoulders must remain settled. Any violation of these fundamentals (e.g. chin jutted up, legs too low, back arching) is documented in pilates form guides ¹¹ ¹⁰.

Bridge Hold (Glute Bridge)

- **Hips (Priority 1):** The pelvis should be lifted so the body forms a straight line from knees to shoulders at the top of the bridge. Avoid **overextending (hyperextending) the hips** beyond horizontal ¹³. “Lifting too high” often causes lumbar arch. Conversely, if the hips are too low (knees drive more than hips), the glutes aren't fully engaged – also an error. Score deductions for any excessive pelvic rotation or tipping.
- **Glutes (Priority 2):** Engage the gluteal muscles as primary movers. A common error is letting the **hamstrings take over** ¹⁴. If the athlete feels the effort in the hamstrings rather than in the butt, it

may mean the glutes aren't firing. In practice, this shows as the back lifting first or hips sagging unevenly. Penalize poor glute activation or uneven hip drive.

- **Lower Back (Priority 3):** The lumbar spine should stay relatively neutral (not hyperextended). Watch for **rib-cage flaring or low-back arching** as the hips rise ¹⁵. In particular, avoid letting the stomach relax and the ribs lift toward the ceiling – that indicates losing core brace ¹⁵. Any noticeable lumbar curvature beyond the minimal needed for lift should be marked off.
- **Knees (Priority 4):** Knees should stay in line with hips and ankles (generally hip-width). Common faults include **knees caving in or splaying outward** (valgus or varus). Although glute bridges emphasize hip extension, misaligned knees (e.g. falling inward) reduce stability and should cost points. Ensure feet are placed so shins are vertical and heels drive down ¹⁶.

References: Form cues stress hip extension without back arch ¹³ ¹⁶. The goal is hip-driven motion: “lift your pelvis... no higher than if a plank of wood connected knee to shoulder” ¹³. Overarching or rib-flaring mistakes occur when core control is lost ¹⁵. Keeping knees aligned under hips is also noted in training guides ¹⁶.

Single-Leg Bridge Hold

- **Hips (Priority 1):** When one leg is lifted, the **pelvis must remain level** (no hip drop) ¹⁷. The support leg's glute drives the hip up. If the lifted side's hip dips or the pelvis rotates, the exercise breaks form. Penalize any downward tilt of the free-leg hip or twisting of the pelvis.
- **Core (Priority 2):** Core stabilization is crucial under the asymmetric load. The spine and pelvis must stay neutral without flexion or side-bending. Watch for the torso leaning toward or away from the support side. If the trunk leans or the spine curves to compensate, deduct points.
- **Glutes (Priority 3):** The supporting leg's glute should be maximally engaged. A common problem is **“standing leg glute not engaging”** (reflected by low hip height). The athlete should “drive hips up by supporting on one foot” ¹⁷. If the hips fail to rise to a straight-line position (from knee to shoulder), mark it.
- **Knees (Priority 4):** The planted knee should remain roughly under the hip (not collapsing inward) ¹⁶. In single-leg stance, it's critical that the knee track over the toes. Any inward collapse (valgus) or locking (hyperextension) of the standing knee during the bridge indicates poor alignment and incurs deductions.

References: The single-leg bridge is a more advanced bridge requiring hip-level control ¹⁷. Instructors cue to anchor one foot and extend the other while driving the hip up ¹⁷. The support knee and torso must stabilize; misalignment in these areas shows core/glute weakness and should be penalized.

Swan Hold (Pilates Swan Dive – Prone Back Extension)

- **Lower Back (Priority 1):** The movement is a controlled thoracic extension, **not** a lumbar hinge. A key mistake is **overusing the lumbar spine** (arching the low back) instead of extending evenly through the mid-back ¹⁸. Judge that the lift comes from thoracic extension with hip extension, keeping the low back lengthened. If the low back hyperextends (excess arch) on its own, substantial deductions apply.
- **Core (Priority 2):** Deep abdominals must contract to protect the spine during back extension. Failure to engage the core (“stack the spine” vs. fold at the waist) makes the lower back vulnerable ¹⁹. The

correct form creates a small gap (hand's width) between mat and abdomen. If the torso lifts mainly by back musculature (with floppy abs), take off points.

- **Neck (Priority 3):** Keep the cervical spine long. The chin should not lift excessively or lead the movement ²⁰. An overextended neck (eyes looking up or forward) indicates form breakdown. Encourage a “crown leading” posture (gaze forward/down) ²⁰. Over-arching the neck must be penalized.
- **Shoulders (Priority 4):** Scapulae should be held down and back. Do **not shrug** or hunch the shoulders during the extension. A common error is shrugging the shoulders toward the ears. Ensure the chest opens but shoulders stay “back and down” to properly involve the upper back. Points off for rounded or collapsed shoulders.
- **Glutes (Priority 5):** The gluteal muscles assist in lifting the legs. Make sure the glutes are **actively contracting** on the support leg side to elevate the thigh without lumbar compensation. If the glutes are loose (resulting in minimal leg lift or trunk compensation), reduce the score. Proper form has the pelvis stabilized by the glutes throughout.

References: Pilates guides stress lengthening the spine and engaging the posterior chain in swan dive ²¹. Instructors warn against hinging only at the lumbar spine ²¹. A primary tip is to “engage glutes and abdominals, distribute extension evenly from the thoracic spine” ²¹. Neck strain is also cautioned against – keeping a “long neck” with gaze slightly down is advised ²⁰.

Side Kick Kneeling

- **Hips (Priority 1):** The hips must stay level and square. Avoid the hip of the lifted leg **dropping or shifting** ²² ²³. The top leg moves, but the pelvis should not tilt toward the down side. If the hips lurch or one hip elevates, the lateral obliques are not stabilizing – deduct points.
- **Core (Priority 2):** A tight core is required to keep the trunk upright. Watch for **torso leaning or arching** as the leg kicks. The instructions emphasize keeping the core tight so “your hips don’t drop or rotate” ²². If the athlete sways or allows the ribs to push out, points should be removed for low engagement.
- **Shoulders (Priority 3):** The supporting arm should hold steady without collapsing. The cue is to keep shoulders **relaxed yet stable** ²⁴. Do not let the shoulder of the supporting arm slump or shrug. Tight, congested shoulders (hunching) indicate poor stabilization. Penalize any shoulder “creeping” or bearing weight disproportionately (e.g. leaning on the arm).
- **Knees (Priority 4):** The kneeling leg’s knee should remain under the hip and foot. Misalignment (knee too far back or forward) can compromise balance. No explicit instructions were given, but generally **weight distribution** should be even. If the kneeling knee collapses inward or shifts strangely, deduct modestly.

References: Pilates instructions for Side Kick Kneeling emphasize hip and core stability ²² ²³. The trainer notes: “keep your hips stable and avoid rotation to fully engage your core” ²³. Shoulders should remain down (avoiding tension) ²⁴. These cues form the basis for scoring alignment.

Superman Hold (Prone Superman Extension)

- **Neck (Priority 1):** The head should align with the spine. Coaching cues say to keep the **nose pointing toward the ground**, not looking ahead ²⁵. Common mistake: craning the neck upward or gazing forward. Penalize any neck hyperextension.

- **Core (Priority 2):** Core muscles (especially the lower abdominals) must brace first. Instruction is to “engage the core, glutes, and back” before lifting ²⁶ . If the lift comes only from the back extensors with a floppy belly, deduction is warranted. An active core helps stabilize the pelvis; lack of it usually shows as excessive lumbar arch or inability to lift legs/torso together.
- **Lower Back/Glutes (Priority 3):** The lift should involve the entire posterior chain. The hips and thighs should rise **in unison** with the torso, aiming to get belly button and thighs off the ground ²⁷ . Avoid hyperextending only the spine. Also, watch for the common error of lifting the legs (glutes) or arms beyond control. As one source notes, “lifting legs and arms too high...can cause pain” ²⁸ . If the athlete overshoots their range of control (e.g. hitches legs way up and hyperextends), subtract points.
- **Shoulders/Arms (Priority 4):** The arms should be straight out with no scapular shrug. Encourage a wide chest and drawn-back shoulders. A suggested fix for shoulder discomfort is to bring arms by the sides if overhead is uncomfortable ²⁹ . Penalize if the athlete hunches the shoulders or grips neck during the hold.
- **Legs (Priority 5):** Glutes and hamstrings activate to lift the legs. “Tight hip flexors can shift the load to the lower back” when legs are raised ²⁹ . Ideally, legs lift slightly (couple of inches) by engaging glutes rather than pushing up too high. Deduct for improper glute activation (legs drifting or not lifting together) or any knee hyperextension on locked legs.

References: Technique advice from Men’s Health and SELF.com stresses head alignment and core/glute engagement ²⁶ ²⁹ . Instructors warn against lifting arms/legs too high (exceeding one’s mobility) ²⁸ and recommend focusing on reaching out through the spine rather than arching up high ²⁹ . These guidelines form the basis of deducting excess lumbar or cervical extension and reward controlled, aligned lifting.

References

- Cathe Friedrich, *5 Plank Mistakes That Can Affect Your Gains* ¹ ² ⁴ ³
- Carolina Rehab, *The Worst Side Plank Mistakes (how-to)* ⁹ ⁶ ⁷
- Verywell Fit, *How to Do the Pilates Hundred* ¹¹ ¹⁰ ¹²
- Body & Spine Solutions, *Top 5 Glute Bridge Mistakes* ¹³ ¹⁴ ¹⁵
- Hevy (fitness site), *Glute Bridge How-to and Mistakes* ³⁰ ³¹
- Peloton Blog, *How to Do (and Avoid Mistakes in) Swan Dive* ²¹ ³²
- Famme (Pilates blog), *Side Kick Kneeling* ²² ²³
- Men’s Health, *Superman Hold* ²⁶
- SELF.com, *The Superman Exercise...* ²⁹ ²⁸

Each reference provides exercise technique guidance or common error descriptions that inform the scoring rules above.

¹ ² ³ ⁴ 5 Plank Mistakes That Can Affect Your Gains and Increase injuries

<https://cathe.com/5-plank-mistakes-that-can-affect-your-gains-and-increase-the-risk-of-injury/>

⁵ ⁶ ⁷ ⁸ ⁹ The Worst Side Plank Mistakes and How to Fix Them | Carolina Rehab

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